



▲ A SUITCASE RADIO

The British Mk III Suitcase Transceiver was designed for use by agents of Britain's Special Operations Executive (SOE) and resistance groups. All its components were miniaturized, although it still required valves, as transistors had not yet been invented.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

TANKS AND INFANTRY IN WORLD WAR II

Land-based conflict in World War II extended across the globe, from the North African desert to the jungles of New Guinea and the streets of Berlin. Tanks and trucks made warfare more mobile, but did not eradicate the need for gruelling infantry combat.

Between the two World Wars, a number of army officers, including J F C Fuller in the UK, Heinz Guderian in Germany, and Mikhail Tukhachevsky in the Soviet Union, explored the use of tanks as the key strike force. Developments in tank design – improving speed, reliability, and armament – lent this vision credibility.

BLITZKREIG

Nazi Germany gave fullest rein to armoured war, and defeated Allied ground forces in France in May–June 1940. Using their *Blitzkrieg* (“lightning war”) tactics, German tanks and motorized infantry, supported by aircraft as “aerial artillery”, broke

through Allied lines in the Ardennes. Mobile radios solved the communication problems of World War I, allowing generals to keep in touch with advancing forces, and facilitating combined ground and air manoeuvres. As the war progressed, countermeasures were introduced, including mines, anti-tank guns, and infantry anti-tank weapons. The development of self-propelled guns provided artillery support for mobile forces, and also gave extra firepower to destroy advancing tanks.

Most infantry entered the war with the same bolt-action rifles issued in World War I, although the US Army had adopted the semi-automatic M1 Garand in 1936. By the end of the war, German

► TANK WARFARE

Following variable battlefield performance in World War I, the tank became a crucial part of land forces in World War II, both for Allied and Axis armies.

KEY FIGURE

GENERAL PATTON 1885–1945

George S Patton first commanded tanks during World War I. During World War II, he became America's most aggressive practitioner of armoured warfare, from North Africa and Sicily, to the spectacular dash across France in the summer of 1944. He excelled in defeating a desperate, final counter-offensive by the Germans in the Ardennes, in the winter of 1944–45.



▲ Patton was a controversial commander, often feared as well as respected.

